CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

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RE: MPs return to Canberra after Haines attack · ADF full-time force tops 64,000 · Wale presses PALM employers for 5,000 places a year · NZ enrolment closes 13 days out · Fiji constitution consultations draw NFP ultimatum

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,795	0.7038	13,734	0.5701
-0.13%	+0.95%	-0.14%	+0.74%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. The Australian Defence Force has grown past *64,000* full-time personnel, its largest size in 25 years, the Guardian reports, as recruiters pitch rising conflict risk to prospective enlistees.
2. Solomon Islands Prime Minister **Matthew Wale** challenged employers approved under Australia's PALM scheme to recruit *5,000* Solomon Islanders a year, PNG Post-Courier reports.
3. New Zealand's enrolment deadline closed at midnight Sunday, with **Christopher Luxon** rejecting claims the rule change disenfranchised voters and the chief electoral officer conceding it would cut enrolments.

TOP STORIES

AU-DEFENSE

ADF recruitment climbs as full-time force hits 25-year high

The Australian Defence Force has grown to more than *64,000* full-time personnel across the navy, army and air force this year, its largest size in 25 years, the Guardian reports. The growth comes as perceptions of regional conflict risk rise. Recruiters are pitching the services directly to prospective enlistees, including at a session in Parramatta in Sydney's west led by army corporal **Joel Kellner**. Recruitment and retention shortfalls have constrained Australian force structure planning for most of the past decade.

per Guardian Australia: "We want you! ADF recruitment rates are growing, even as the odds of conflict rise. Why are people signing up?"

AU-POLITICS

Parliament resumes for first sitting week since Haines attack

Members of Parliament returned to Canberra on Sunday for the first sitting week since independent MP **Helen Haines** lost her legs in an alleged attack outside her electorate office in Wangaratta, SMH reports. The return follows an alleged threat against staff at the office of Western Australian MP **Hannah Beazley** and a week of public reflection by politicians across jurisdictions on their physical safety. AFP Commissioner **Krissy Barrett** told the ABC there is a direct correlation between political speech and abuse directed at parliamentarians.

per SMH: "MPs return to Canberra after Helen Haines alleged attack" · also ABC News

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Solomon Islands PM presses Australian employers to lift PALM intake to 5,000 a year

Solomon Islands Prime Minister **Matthew Wale** challenged employers approved under Australia's Pacific Australia Labour Mobility scheme to help recruit *5,000* Solomon Islanders annually for work in Australia, PNG Post-Courier reports. The challenge was issued directly to PALM-approved employers. Labour mobility is the largest single channel of Australian economic engagement with Solomon Islands, whose prime minister currently chairs the Pacific Islands Forum.

per PNG Post-Courier: "Wale challenges PALM employers to recruit 5,000 Solomon Islanders annually"

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Australia names Rachel Moseley arms control and counter-proliferation ambassador · Xinhua

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** announced **Rachel Moseley** as Australia's next Ambassador for Arms Control and Counter-Proliferation, succeeding **Vanessa Wood**, who has held the post since 2023. Moseley, currently assistant secretary of the Arms Control and Counter-Proliferation Branch at the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, previously served as ambassador to Mexico with postings in Papua New Guinea and Geneva. Her brief includes promoting Australia's non-proliferation standards in acquiring conventionally armed, nuclear-powered submarines.

AU-DEFENSE

HMAS Eyre takes freedom of entry at Port Lincoln · ABC News

The Royal Australian Navy's newest patrol boat, HMAS Eyre, was welcomed to Port Lincoln in South Australia with a freedom of entry ceremony. Navigator Lieutenant **Katie Webb**, a Port Lincoln local and ten-year navy veteran, led the guard section of the procession and plotted the ship's route to its namesake city. Most of the vessel's duties will involve working with Border Force, the federal police, and the Australian Fisheries Management Authority.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Chalmers tells FT middle powers must co-operate against geopolitical capture · Financial Times

Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** told the Financial Times that middle powers should co-operate to avoid becoming hostage to geopolitics. The remarks land as Australia balances security alignment with the United States against its trade exposure to China.

TRADE-ECONOMY

RBA chief economist concedes government spending is feeding demand · AFR

The Reserve Bank's chief economist acknowledged that government spending is contributing to economic demand, the AFR reports, ahead of the release of new inflation data. The RBA cash rate stands at 4.35 percent after a unanimous hold on 11 August, the second consecutive hold following three increases earlier in 2026.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Boyer Lecture urges reckoning with Australia's Chinese history · ABC News

Louisa Lim, associate professor at the University of Melbourne and a former NPR and BBC China correspondent, used this year's Boyer Lecture series on Australia's engagement with Asia to argue that much Chinese-Australian history has been lost and forgotten, and that ignorance of it will hold the country back. Lim is the first Asian Boyer lecturer.

AU-POLITICS

Industry and farm groups warn Labor against capping carbon offsets · The Australian

Industry bodies and farmers have warned the Albanese government against imposing a cap on carbon offsets in its emissions reduction framework, The Australian reports. The dispute reopens a front in Australian climate policy that bears directly on the trajectory of the safeguard mechanism.

STAT OF THE DAY

64,000

ADF full-time personnel across navy, army, air force

The force is now the largest in 25 years, with recruitment rising as regional conflict risk perceptions climb.

Guardian Australia

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji's NFP makes support for constitution bill conditional on December extension

National Federation Party president **Parmod Chand** told the Special Parliamentary Committee in Labasa that his party's continued participation in the Constitution Amendment Bill process depends on extending public consultations to at least mid-December and making substantive changes to the bill. Chand said the public was initially given 13 days to make submissions while the committee had 20 days to complete its work, and criticised the failure to publish the bill's provisions in English, Vosa Vakaviti, and Hindi.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

Chaudhry tells constitution hearing religion and state must stay separate

Former Prime Minister **Mahendra Chaudhry** told the Constitution Amendment Bill consultation in Labasa that religion and the state must remain separate to protect Fiji's multiracial society, and that provisions favouring one religion could create serious divisions. He described the bill as divisive, undemocratic, and discriminatory in several provisions, and argued Fiji should prioritise poverty, unemployment, drug trafficking, and HIV over a new constitution.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islands opposition leader sets four-year agenda on health and accountability

The incoming Leader of the Opposition in the Cook Islands has set out an agenda for the next four years focused on health services, the cost of living, and greater government accountability and transparency, Cook

Islands News reports.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Sacked Cook Islands minister keeps salary to December as assets recalled

Sacked interim cabinet minister **George Maggie Angene** will continue to receive his ministerial salary until 18 December, while moves were underway this week to retrieve government assets including a vehicle, Cook Islands News reports.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

ADB launches 2026-2030 country partnership strategy for PNG

The Asian Development Bank launched its Country Partnership Strategy 2026-2030 for Papua New Guinea in Port Moresby on October 21, 2026, PNG Post-Courier reports. ADB PNG country director **Takafumi Kadono** heads the bank's resident mission.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG Public Accounts Committee plans inspections across all 22 provinces

Papua New Guinea's Public Accounts Committee announced plans to inspect provincial hospitals and health centres across all *22* provinces, with the proposed visits scheduled to begin in November 2026, PNG Post-Courier reports.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fijian officer becomes first RFMF graduate of US Marine Corps Basic School

Second-Lieutenant **Akuila Vute** received the United States Marine Corps Basic School badge at Marine Corps Base Quantico in Virginia on October 22 and graduated the following day, the first Republic of Fiji Military Forces officer to complete the programme. Fiji's Ambassador to the United States **Ilisoni Vuidreketi** and Colonel **Daunivakasala Ravunakana** attended the ceremony.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islands ICT department alerts other governments to PHP vulnerabilities

The Cook Islands government's Information and Communication Technology Department warned other governments about multiple critical vulnerabilities in core PHP, Cook Islands News reports. Pacific government cyber capacity has been a recurring theme in regional security assistance programmes.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Luxon denies disenfranchising voters as enrolment closes 13 days out

Chief electoral officer **Karl le Quesne** told TVNZ's Q&A it was "fair" to say the rule change requiring enrolment by midnight Sunday would reduce enrolments, though it was "hard to say" how much until after the November 7 election. **Christopher Luxon** said the government was "absolutely not" disenfranchising people, pointing to a near doubling of Electoral Commission turnout advertising. Labour leader **Chris Hipkins** also urged voters to enrol.

NZ-POLITICS · STUFF

National releases 100-day plan as Luxon warns election will go to the wire

Christopher Luxon released National's 100-day plan for a second term, telling supporters the November 7 election is going down to the wire, Stuff reports. The plan sets out the party's first actions if re-elected.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

National removes campaign volunteer over 2021 conviction

National removed **Roger Buchanan**, a volunteer and member of its Palmerston North electorate committee, after learning of his conviction for sexual conduct with a minor. **Christopher Luxon** said he had only just

become aware of the matter and was glad the party acted swiftly. A party spokesperson said National "stands with victims of sexual violence."

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Luxon distinguishes his gang photograph from opposition images

Christopher Luxon said a photo of him with Black Power members, taken at the Crown apology to survivors of abuse in care and posted by Mongrel Mob life member **Harry Tam**, differs from images of Labour, Green, and Te Pati Maori candidates. Luxon said abuse in state care "might well play a role" in people joining gangs but that it remained "still unacceptable, people have free will and choice."

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

AFP commissioner links threats against MPs directly to political debate

AFP Commissioner **Krissy Barrett** told the ABC there is a "direct correlation" between political speech and abuse directed at federal parliamentarians. The AFP has acknowledged that violent threats against federal MPs are rising following the attack on **Helen Haines**.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Haines was lead advocate for study on MP safety due out next month

Helen Haines spent the past year advocating for a Berlin-based Better Politics Foundation study mapping physical and mental health risks to elected representatives, the ABC reports. The draft report, titled Fit To Lead, canvassed *288* current and five former federal, state, and local representatives and is due for release next month. Haines's office authorised the ABC to attribute to her the report's opening quote: "You shouldn't have to wear a flak jacket, physical or emotional, to do the job."

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

WA MPs say accessibility is becoming harder after Beazley office threat

Western Australian energy minister **Amber-Jade Sanderson** said it is "becoming more and more challenging to do this job" after staff at colleague **Hannah Beazley**'s office were allegedly threatened. Labor backbencher **Mark Folkard**, a former police officer, disclosed he is dealing with a stalker and questioned what is driving the hostility.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Western Sydney International opens, with airport boss ruling out further funding

The *$5.3 billion* Western Sydney International airport opened to commercial passengers on Sunday with an inaugural Jetstar service, the first time an Australian capital city has had two major international airports. Flights will be sparse initially, and the airport's chief executive ruled out seeking additional funding, The Australian reports.

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Melbourne's eastern suburbs shape up as the Victorian election battleground

A Coalition win at Victoria's November state election could turn on promises about law and order, infrastructure, and economic management in Melbourne's changing eastern suburbs, the Guardian reports. Victorian Labor launched its campaign with a *$1.5 billion* health package to expand a dozen hospital emergency departments, hire 1,500 health workers, and add 150 beds, against a $1.3 billion Liberal surgery wait-time plan.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Pyxis extends contract to conduct Newspoll for four more years

Research firm Pyxis has extended its partnership to run Newspoll, the most closely watched Australian political survey, for a further four years, The Australian reports.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · NIKKEI ASIA

Australian grower exports first 'ecoganic' bananas into Asian markets

Queensland banana grower **Frank Sciacca** set out in 1998 to develop an alternative cultivation method after growing disillusioned with his farm's conventional approach, Nikkei Asia reports. The resulting red-tipped fruit is Australia's first certified 'ecoganic' export.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · AUSTRALIAN MINISTER FOR FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Wong holds press conference at Australia-Papua New Guinea Ministerial Forum

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** gave a press conference at the Australia-Papua New Guinea Ministerial Forum, per a transcript published by her office. The forum is the principal standing bilateral mechanism between Canberra and Port Moresby.

UPCOMING

OCT 26 — **Australian parliamentary sitting week resumes, first since the attack on Helen Haines**
MP security arrangements and the political temperature will dominate the return, with the AFP publicly linking threats to political debate.

OCT 26 — **Advance voting opens in the New Zealand general election**
Early voting begins the day after the enrolment deadline that the chief electoral officer says will reduce the roll.

NOV 7 — **New Zealand general election**
Determines whether the National, ACT, and NZ First coalition continues, with Winston Peters's foreign affairs portfolio and Judith Collins's defence agenda at stake.

NOV 2026 — **PNG Public Accounts Committee begins hospital and health centre inspections across 22 provinces**
Provincial health service delivery is a central test of PNG budget execution and of donor-funded health programming.

NOV 2026 — **Better Politics Foundation releases Fit To Lead report on Australian MP safety**
The largest survey of Australian representatives' safety and mental health lands into an active debate on parliamentary security.

THE WIRE

TRADE-ECONOMY

SMH

Backers hope second Sydney airport delivers aviation competition

Supporters of Western Sydney International argue a second major international airport in one capital city could deliver cheaper tickets and more flights through competition, SMH reports.

AU-POLITICS

GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Schultz: AFP and ASIO data contradict the claim that this is not who Australians are

Julianne Schultz writes that after the alleged attack on **Helen Haines**, the prime minister and others said "this is not who we Australians are," but data from the Australian Federal Police, ASIO, and the experience of individual MPs suggests otherwise.

NZ-POLITICS

NEWSROOM NZ

Smale calls the gang photo contest ignorant and hypocritical

Investigative journalist **Aaron Smale** writes that the political posturing over photographs with gang members during the New Zealand campaign is ignorant and hypocritical, amounting to what he calls gangster chic for Instagram.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

FIJIVILLAGE

Shameem Khan says ICC progressing despite US sanctions

Fijian jurist **Nazhat Shameem Khan** said the International Criminal Court is making significant progress despite United States sanctions, Fijivillage reports.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Aitutaki launches lagoon management plan

Aitutaki has launched a lagoon management plan with a call to renew stewardship, Cook Islands News reports, quoting the appeal: "Our grandparents, our tupuna, handed this lagoon to us. So let us not be the generation that lets it go."

FIJI SUN

Fiji parliament travel and communications costs double to $2.4 million

Fiji's parliamentary travel and communication spending rose from $1.2 million in 2023 to *$2.4 million* in 2024. Opposition MP **Rinesh Sharma** questioned secretary-general **Jeanette Emberson**, who attributed the rise to higher MP entitlements and an expanding workload.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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